

Perspectives

Character & Grammar Through Stories

Episode 3 – The Commute

Level: B2–C1 (IELTS Band 6.5–8.0)

Student Name: _____

Date: _____

Level: B2–C1

Learning Goals

- ✓ Read and interpret a discursive, opinion-based story
- ✓ Distinguish defining from non-defining relative clauses
- ✓ Use reduced (contact) relative clauses with the pronoun omitted
- ✓ Form and use present, past, and perfect participle clauses
- ✓ Acquire an extended set of Academic Word List vocabulary and collocations
- ✓ Practise IELTS-style sentence transformation and error correction
- ✓ Produce an IELTS Task 2-style discursive paragraph
- ✓ Reflect critically on fairness, trade-offs, and systemic decision-making

SECTION 1 | WARM-UP — Before You Read

Part A — Prediction & Opinion Questions

Instructions: These questions require you to take a position, not just guess a plot. Answer before reading.

1. To what extent do you agree that large infrastructure projects should prioritise the greatest number of people, even if this means some communities wait much longer than others?

2. Some people believe that public consultations rarely change real decisions, and exist mainly to make people feel heard. To what extent do you agree?

Part B — Personal Reflection

Instructions: Answer honestly from your own experience or context.

1. How long is your daily commute, and what is the most frustrating part of it?

2. If you could redesign one part of your city's transport system, what would you change first, and why?

SECTION 2 | MAIN STORY — Read the Story

Instructions: Read the story carefully. Underline every relative clause (defining or non-defining), and circle every participle clause (present, past, or perfect).

The Commute

Farzana, who has worked at a private bank in Motijheel for the past four years, spends nearly three hours every day travelling to and from her office in Mirpur — a commute that, under normal circumstances, should take no more than forty minutes. The single flyover near her route had long ago become the city's most notorious bottleneck, and some mornings the congestion dissolved into complete gridlock before she had even left her own neighbourhood. Having left home before seven for as long as she can remember, she had grown used to mornings that began in darkness and evenings that ended the same way.

On a rare free Saturday, she noticed a small notice pinned to the gate of the local ward office, announcing a public consultation on a proposed metro rail corridor — a route that, according to the notice, would eventually connect several densely populated areas to the existing network. Curious, and frankly a little unconvinced, she decided to attend.

The meeting was led by Architect Kamal Reza, an urban planner who had spent nearly a decade working on Dhaka's transport projects. Having presented the proposed route on a large printed map, he opened the floor to questions.

Farzana raised her hand. “The map you've shown us doesn't include Mirpur-2, which is where thousands of commuters like me actually live. Why does this corridor skip the area that arguably needs it most?”

Kamal Reza, who had clearly answered variations of this question many times before, nodded patiently. “That's a fair question, and I won't pretend there's a simple answer. The corridor was prioritised using ridership data collected over three years — data that showed higher potential passenger volume along the route we've chosen. Mirpur-2, unfortunately, didn't score as highly in that particular model.”

“So residents whose daily commute is already unbearable,” Farzana replied, “are being asked to wait for a phase that might not exist for another decade — because a model, built from data none of us ever saw, decided we mattered less?”

A murmur passed through the room; several people nodded, clearly feeling as marginalised by the process as she did. Kamal Reza paused before answering. “I understand why that sounds unfair. A city that tried to fund every route at once would build nothing well. Budgets have to be allocated somewhere first, sometimes at the expense of neighbourhoods like your own. The extension approved for this phase is the one projected to relieve congestion for the largest number of people, not necessarily the people facing the worst individual commutes today.”

“That's a difference that matters enormously if you're one of the people not being helped,” Farzana said quietly.

“It does,” he admitted. “I'm not going to stand here and tell you this plan is equitable for everyone, because it isn't, not yet. What I can tell you is that the data used to exclude Mirpur-2 this year is also the data that will justify including it in the next phase — assuming the growth pattern continues, and assuming next year's budget is actually approved. There is, in fact, a second corridor, still only in the pipeline, that would eventually reach your area as well.”

“And if the budget isn't approved?” someone else asked.

“Then we go back to the drawing board on prioritisation, and areas like Mirpur-2 keep waiting,” Kamal Reza said. “I won't pretend that's a satisfying answer. It's simply the honest one.”

After the meeting ended, Farzana remained for a while, looking again at the printed map pinned to the board. A young volunteer, noticing her still standing there, offered to note her comments for the official record. Farzana wrote a short paragraph — measured, unlike the frustration she had walked in with — asking that Mirpur-2's data be weighed up again before the next phase was finalised.

Walking home, she thought about what Kamal Reza had said. A transport system designed to help the most people possible would, by definition, leave some people waiting, even when a fully equitable plan felt more feasible in theory than viable within an actual limited budget. That didn't make her three-hour commute any shorter. But she found, somewhat unwillingly, that she no longer knew whether to be angry at the planners or simply at the scale of the problem itself.

She still had no faster way home that evening. But she had, for the first time, a clearer picture of why.

SECTION 3 | VOCABULARY ZONE

Instructions: Study the words and collocations below. This episode's list is longer than usual — take your time and revisit it after reading the story.

Word / Phrase	Part of Speech	Simple English Meaning	বাংলা অর্থ
commute	noun/verb	the regular journey between home and work	নিত্যযাত্রা / যাতায়াত করা
congestion	noun	overcrowding, especially of traffic	যানজট / ভিড়
gridlock	noun	a situation in which traffic is not moving at all	সম্পূর্ণ যানজট
bottleneck	noun	a point that slows down or blocks progress	সংকীর্ণ বাধাস্থল
corridor	noun	a route or passage, especially for transport	যাতায়াত করিডোর
ridership	noun	the number of people who use a transport service	যাত্রী সংখ্যা
consultation	noun	a meeting held to gather opinions before a decision	পরামর্শ সভা
prioritise	verb	to treat something as more urgent than other things	অগ্রাধিকার দেওয়া
phase	noun	a distinct stage in a process	পর্যায়
allocate	verb	to give a share of a resource for a particular purpose	বরাদ্দ করা
equitable	adjective	fair and impartial, giving everyone a fair share	ন্যায্য / সমতাপূর্ণ
marginalised	adjective	pushed to the edge of consideration; treated as unimportant	প্রান্তিক করা হয়েছে এমন
feasible	adjective	possible to do in practice	বাস্তবসম্মত
viable	adjective	capable of working successfully in real conditions	কার্যকর হতে সক্ষম
unconvinced	adjective	not persuaded that something is true or right	অপ্রত্যয়ী
relieve	verb	to reduce the severity of a problem	লাঘব করা
data-driven	adjective	based on evidence and statistics rather than opinion	উপাত্তভিত্তিক
densely populated	phrase	having a very high number of people per area	ঘনবসতিপূর্ণ
in the pipeline	phrase	being planned or developed, not yet complete	পরিকল্পনাধীন
at the expense of	phrase	causing harm or disadvantage to something else	কিছুর মূল্যে / ক্ষতির বিনিময়ে

Word / Phrase	Part of Speech	Simple English Meaning	বাংলা অর্থ
back to the drawing board	phrase	starting a plan again from the very beginning	নতুন করে পরিকল্পনা শুরু করা
weigh up	phrasal verb	to consider the advantages and disadvantages carefully	ভালোমন্দ বিবেচনা করা

Task A — Matching

Instructions: Match each word with its correct meaning. Write the letter in the Your Answer column.

Word	Your Answer
1. bottleneck	_____
2. equitable	_____
3. marginalised	_____
4. prioritise	_____
5. ridership	_____
6. viable	_____
7. feasible	_____
8. consultation	_____

- A. a point that slows down or blocks progress
- B. fair and impartial, giving everyone a fair share
- C. pushed to the edge of consideration
- D. to treat something as more urgent than other things
- E. the number of people who use a transport service
- F. capable of working successfully in real conditions
- G. possible to do in practice
- H. a meeting held to gather opinions before a decision

Task B — Fill in the Blanks

Instructions: Choose the best word or phrase from the box and complete the sentences.

Word Box: **gridlock** | **allocate** | **densely populated** | **unconvinced** | **in the pipeline** | **at the expense of** | **back to the drawing board**

- By eight in the morning, the main road near Farzana's house was in complete _____.
- The city could not _____ funds to every neighbourhood at the same time.
- The proposed corridor was designed to serve some of the most _____ parts of the city.
- Farzana remained _____ even after Kamal Reza explained the ridership model.
- A second corridor is still _____ and may not be built for several years.
- Kamal Reza admitted that some communities were being helped _____ others.
- If the budget fails, planners may have to go _____ on the whole project.

Task C — Vocabulary in Context

Instructions: Read each quotation from the story and guess the meaning of the underlined word or phrase from context.

1. "The single flyover near her route had long ago become the city's most notorious bottleneck." What does notorious suggest about the bottleneck?

2. "Budgets have to be allocated somewhere first." What does allocated mean here?

3. "Several people nodded, clearly feeling as marginalised by the process as she did." What does marginalised mean in this context?

4. "I'm not going to stand here and tell you this plan is equitable for everyone." What does equitable mean here?

5. "A fully equitable plan felt more feasible in theory than viable within an actual limited budget." What is the difference being suggested between feasible and viable?

6. "Then we go back to the drawing board on prioritisation." What does this phrase suggest happens next?

Task D — Personal Vocabulary Journal

Instructions: Choose 4 new words or phrases from this episode. Write the Bangla meaning and your own English sentence.

No.	New Word/Phrase	বাংলা অর্থ	My Own English Sentence
1			
2			
3			
4			

SECTION 4 | GRAMMAR DETECTIVE 🔍 — Relative Clauses & Participle Clauses

Task A — Find from the Story

Instructions: Find and copy the required number of examples for each grammar focus from the story.

Grammar Focus	Examples from the Story
2 Defining Relative Clauses	_____
2 Non-Defining Relative Clauses	_____
2 Reduced Relative Clauses (pronoun omitted)	_____
2 Present Participle Clauses (-ing)	_____
2 Past / Perfect Participle Clauses (V3 / Having + V3)	_____

Task B — Grammar Lab

Instructions: For each sentence, identify the structure, explain why it is used, and write a similar sentence of your own.

1. *“Farzana, who has worked at a private bank in Motijheel for the past four years, spends nearly three hours every day travelling.”*

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

2. *“A route that, according to the notice, would eventually connect several densely populated areas.”*

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

3. *“Data that showed higher potential passenger volume along the route we’ve chosen.”*

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

4. *“Having left home before seven for as long as she can remember, she had grown used to mornings that began in darkness.”*

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

5. *“A young volunteer, noticing her still standing there, offered to note her comments.”*

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

6. "The data used to exclude Mirpur-2 this year is also the data that will justify including it in the next phase."

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

SECTION 5 | MIXED GRAMMAR CHALLENGE

A — Error Correction

Instructions: Each sentence contains one error in a relative clause or participle clause. Rewrite it correctly.

1. Farzana, that has worked at the bank for four years, commutes for three hours a day.

2. The corridor that skip Mirpur-2 was chosen using ridership data.

3. Have left home before seven, Farzana felt tired every morning.

4. Kamal Reza, he had answered this question many times, nodded patiently.

5. The data using to exclude Mirpur-2 will justify including it later.

6. A young volunteer, notice her still standing there, offered to help.

B — Multiple Choice

Instructions: Choose the best answer: A, B, C, or D.

1. Farzana, _____ works at a bank in Motijheel, commutes for three hours a day.

A. that B. which C. who D. whom Answer: _____

2. The corridor _____ was chosen used three years of ridership data.

A. who B. that C. whose D. what Answer: _____

3. _____ presented the map, Kamal Reza opened the floor to questions.

A. Have B. Having C. To have D. Had Answer: _____

4. A young volunteer, _____ her still standing there, offered to help.

A. notice B. noticed C. noticing D. to notice Answer: _____

5. The data _____ to exclude Mirpur-2 will also justify including it later.

A. used B. using C. use D. uses Answer: _____

6. Residents _____ daily commute is unbearable are being asked to wait.

A. who B. which C. whose D. that Answer: _____

C — Gap Fill

Instructions: Complete each sentence with the correct participle or relative-clause form of the word in brackets.

1. Farzana, _____ (work) at the bank for four years, was tired of her commute.
2. The route _____ (choose) using ridership data did not include Mirpur-2.
3. _____ (leave) home before seven, she had grown used to dark mornings.
4. The volunteer, _____ (notice) her still standing there, offered to help.
5. A system _____ (design) to help the most people will leave some people waiting.
6. Kamal Reza, _____ (answer) similar questions many times, stayed patient.

D — Sentence Transformation

Instructions: Combine each pair of sentences as directed, using the required grammar structure.

1. **Original:** Farzana works at a bank. She commutes for three hours a day.

Combine using a non-defining relative clause:

Farzana, _____, commutes for three hours a day.

2. **Original:** Kamal Reza presented the map. Then he opened the floor to questions.

Combine using a perfect participle clause (Having...):

_____, he opened the floor to questions.

3. **Original:** The volunteer noticed Farzana standing there. He offered to help.

Combine using a present participle clause:

The volunteer, _____, offered to help.

4. **Original:** Planners used the data to exclude Mirpur-2. The same data will justify including it later.

Combine using a reduced (contact) relative clause:

The data _____ is the same data that will justify including it later.

SECTION 6 | SENTENCE BUILDER — Build Your Own Sentences

Instructions: Use each word or phrase to write one original sentence, following the required grammar structure exactly. Do not copy from the story.

Word / Phrase	Required Grammar Structure	Your Sentence
congestion	Defining relative clause	
corridor	Non-defining relative clause	
ridership	Present participle clause	
consultation	Past participle clause	
equitable	Perfect participle clause (Having...)	
marginalised	Reduced (contact) relative clause	
feasible	Non-defining relative clause	
weigh up	Defining relative clause using 'whose'	

SECTION 7 | SHORT WRITING TASK — Think & Write

Instructions: Write 150–180 words. Use at least two relative clauses (one defining, one non-defining) and one participle clause. Write down the main paragraphs only.

Prompt:

Some people believe that transport authorities should prioritise projects that help the greatest number of people overall, even if this means some communities wait much longer for improvements. Others believe that every neighbourhood deserves equal and immediate investment. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Writing Space

SECTION 8 | CHARACTER REFLECTION — Character Corner

Instructions: These questions have no single correct answer. Discuss with a partner if possible, then write your own considered response.

1. Kamal Reza says, “I’m not going to stand here and tell you this plan is equitable for everyone, because it isn’t, not yet.” What does his willingness to admit this suggest about honest leadership, compared to leadership that simply reassures people?

2. Farzana ends the story with a clearer understanding of the system, but no shorter commute. Is understanding *why* something is unfair a meaningful outcome on its own, even without a solution?

3. To what extent should decisions that affect many people be based purely on data (like ridership numbers), rather than on which communities are struggling the most right now?

4. Is it possible to design any system — transport, education, healthcare — that is fair to absolutely everyone at the same time? What does this story suggest about that question?

5. Farzana chooses to submit a written comment rather than simply remaining angry. What does this suggest about the difference between venting frustration and engaging constructively with a system you disagree with?

SECTION 9 | HOMEWORK

Level 1	Level 2
Write 6 sentences about your city's transport system, each using a relative clause or a participle clause.	Write a reflective diary/essay entry (150–180 words) titled “A Time I Had to Accept an Unsatisfying but Honest Answer.” Use at least 2 relative clauses and 1 participle clause.

Final Reminder: *A well-placed relative clause can carry an entire argument's worth of nuance. Precision in grammar often reflects precision in thought.*